

GA.2 Permit Application Checklist

Everything a Georgia owner-builder gathers, verifies, and files — with the state-level gates that stop a project cold whether or not your county runs a permit counter.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. In Georgia the state minimum codes bind statewide, but permits and inspections are a local option — each county or city decides its own forms, fees, and enforcement, and some enforce nothing at all. Confirm every item with the office that will issue your permit before you rely on it.

THE GEORGIA SPLIT — MANDATORY CODES, LOCAL-OPTION PERMITS

Eight state minimum codes bind your project no matter where in Georgia it sits: *"the state minimum standard codes enumerated in subdivisions (9)(A)(i)(I) through (9)(A)(i)(VIII) and (9)(B)(i)(I) through (9)(B)(i)(VIII) of Code Section 8-2-20 shall have state-wide application and shall not require adoption by a municipality or county"* (§ 8-2-25(a)). The eight are the building, electrical, fuel gas, mechanical, plumbing, residential, energy conservation, and fire codes.

Enforcement is a different statute. Section 8-2-26(a) is a grant of power, not a command: *"The governing body of any municipality or county adopting any state minimum standard code shall have the power"* — and then, at (a)(4), *"To require permits and to fix charges therefor."* Your county **may** run a permit office. Nothing makes it.

If your county has no building department

Then there is no permit to pull — and nothing else changes. Section 8-2-25(a) still binds the work to the eight mandatory codes, and § 43-41-17(h) makes your own exemption conditional on doing the work "in conformity with" them. Enforcement is optional for the *government*; the code is not optional for *you*. No official roster of non-enforcing counties exists — call the county and record its answer in GA.4, and see GA.3 for how to verify your own work when nobody else will.

Two footnotes. The **permissive** codes — property maintenance, existing buildings, green building — apply only where locally adopted (§ 8-2-25(b)). And applicants may retain **private professional providers** for plan review and inspection (§ 8-2-26(g)) — useful where the queue is long; the kit does not print that subsection's procedural terms, so read it before invoking it.

O.C.G.A. § 8-2-25(a), (b); § 8-2-26(a)(4), (g); § 43-41-17(h). Verified August 2026.

THE STATE-LEVEL GATES — CLEAR THESE FIRST

Most of what a permit counter asks for is local. These are not — they are state rules that run on their own tracks, and three of them bite before any ground is broken:

- **1. Septic.** On a lot that will use an on-site sewage system, **no physical development may begin** until the County Health Department issues the septic construction permit. (DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(2) — section C below)
- **2. Land disturbance.** No land-disturbing activity without a permit from the local issuing authority or a notice of intent to EPD — unless your build fits the under-one-acre single-family exemption. (§ 12-7-7(a); § 12-7-17(4) — section D)
- **3. State-route driveway.** Any construction work inside a state highway right of way needs a GDOT permit first, from the District Area Office. (GDOT driveway regulations; § 32-6-131 — section E)
- **4. Notice of Commencement.** Filed within **15 days** of starting work, with the clerk of superior court, and posted on site — or you forfeit the lien-law screen. (§ 44-14-361.5 — section F)

A. SITE AND PROJECT VERIFICATION

A1: Before anything else

	Item	Date	Notes / who confirmed
☐	Confirmed which jurisdiction (city or unincorporated county) your parcel is in — and whether it requires building permits at all (see GA.4)		
☐	Parcel identification number and 911 address confirmed Parcel ID: _____ Address: _____		
☐	Deed recorded in your name — you must own the land to claim the exemption		
☐	Zoning district, permitted use, and setbacks verified in writing with planning/zoning Front: _____ Side: _____ Rear: _____ Other: _____		
☐	Easements, rights-of-way, and recorded restrictions identified		
☐	Flood zone checked with your community's floodplain administrator and the state flood map viewer (georgiadfirm.com) Zone: _____ Confirmed with: _____		

A1: Before anything else

	Item	Date	Notes / who confirmed
☐	HOA or covenant approval obtained if applicable — private, not governmental; the county will not check it for you		

Floodplain construction rules are your community's NFIP ordinance — a local determination from the flood insurance rate map, coordinated at the state level by EPD's Floodplain Management Unit (epd.georgia.gov). This kit prints no elevation or permit rule because there is no statewide one. Verified August 2026.

B. THE APPLICATION PACKAGE**B1: Forms and proofs**

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Building permit application, completed and signed — the form is local; see GA.5 for how to find yours		
☐	County owner-builder affidavit, notarized, if your county requires one (no state form exists — GA.1) Required? Y/N: _____ Form: _____		
☐	Septic construction permit issued (section C) — most counties want it attached to the building application Permit #: _____ Date: _____		
☐	Homeowner trade permits identified — where the county permits electrical, plumbing, and HVAC separately, you apply under the § 43-14-13(d) carve-out; some use a homeowner disclaimer form		
☐	Estimated construction cost stated — this drives the \$2,500 licensing test for your subs and usually the fee Stated cost: \$ _____		
☐	Notice of Commencement drafted and ready to file within 15 days of starting work (section F)		

B2: Plans and supporting drawings

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Plan sets in the count and format your jurisdiction takes (many metro counties are digital-only; ask before printing)		

B2: Plans and supporting drawings

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Site plan showing property lines, setbacks, the building footprint, driveway, well and septic locations, and any easements		
☐	Foundation plan, floor plans, elevations, wall sections, and a framing plan		
☐	Electrical, plumbing and mechanical layouts as your county requires — reviewed against the state IPC, 2023 NEC, and IMC/IFGC, not the IRC chapters (section G)		
☐	Energy code compliance documentation and the two DET tests planned (section G) DET verifier: _____		
☐	Engineered or manufacturer specifications for anything non-standard — trusses, ICF, SIPs, long spans, steep-slope foundations		

C. SEPTIC AND WELL — COUNTY HEALTH, NOT THE BUILDING OFFICE

On-site sewage is permitted by your **County Health Department** under the state DPH rules, on its own track and its own timeline. In Georgia it is the hardest state gate on the whole project, because it bars the ground itself:

No site work on a septic lot until the permit issues — statewide

"No person may begin the physical development of a lot or structure where an on-site sewage management system will be utilized, nor install an on-site sewage management system or component thereof, without having first obtained from the County Health Department a construction permit for the installation of an onsite sewage management system." (DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(2))

Note what is gated: not just the septic install — **the physical development of the lot**. Clearing and grading a septic lot before this permit is a violation. Start here, before you buy the land if you still can.

The mechanics: you apply "in writing on forms provided by the County Board of Health"; the county must *"approve or disapprove such application within twenty days after the receipt of a completed application"* (Rule -.03(2)(a)); the permit issues only after a site inspection *"shows favorable findings relative to absorption rates, soil characteristics, groundwater, rock"* and related factors (Rule -.03(3)); and it *"shall remain valid for not more than twelve months from the date of issue"* (Rule -.03(3)(a)).

Sequencing against the building permit. The state rule bars physical development — it does not say which permit issues first. In practice, Georgia counties nearly universally require the septic permit **before** the building permit; expect to hand it in as an attachment, and confirm your county's order rather than assuming it.

C1: Septic and well

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Septic application filed with the County Health Department on its forms — site inspection scheduled		
☐	Septic construction permit issued after favorable site findings — valid 12 months; no lot development before this Permit #: _____ Date: _____		
☐	System and drainfield location shown on your site plan and consistent with the house footprint and any well		
☐	Final: system not backfilled or used until the county's final inspection and written approval (see GA.3)		
☐	If drilling a well: confirmed the property is your primary residence — the owner-drilling right does not cover land developed for resale Driller/licensee: _____		
☐	Well siting checked against the DPH septic-separation rules, and the county asked whether it approves individual wells County answer: _____		

Wells. The Water Well Standards Act leaves the owner a lane: *"Nothing in this part shall prohibit a person from drilling a well on his or her own property if such property is his or her primary residence."* Land "developing for resale" needs a licensed water well contractor (§ 12-5-131.1(a)). The kit found **no statewide domestic-well permit** — but some county health departments approve individual wells, and well-to-septic separation runs through the DPH on-site sewage rules. Confirm both locally before drilling.

DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(2), (2)(a), (3), (3)(a) — official DPH rules PDF, read directly; O.C.G.A. § 12-5-131.1(a). Septic-before-building-permit sequencing is county practice, not a quotable state rule — the quotable gate is on physical development. Verified August 2026.

D. EROSION, SEDIMENTATION, AND STORMWATER

"No land-disturbing activities shall be conducted in this state, except those land-disturbing activities provided for in Code Section 12-7-17, without the operator first securing a permit from a local issuing authority or providing notice of intent to the division as required by this Code section." (§ 12-7-7(a)) The exemption most owner-builders ride is § 12-7-17(4): "The construction of single-family residences, when such construction disturbs less than one acre and is not a part of a larger common plan of development or sale with a planned disturbance of equal to or greater than one acre."

Exempt from the permit is not exempt from the rules

Even inside the single-family exemption, the § 12-7-6(b) minimum standards — including stream buffers — still apply to your work. And the exemption itself carries provisos for construction near state waters and trout streams that narrow it. This kit deliberately prints no buffer or proximity distances, because it could not verify the exact statutory text — read § 12-7-17 in full and ask your local issuing authority before you rely on the exemption near any stream or lake.

D1: Erosion control and NPDES

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Total land disturbance calculated — house, driveway, septic area, staging and spoil piles Total acres disturbed: _____		
☐	If under one acre and not part of a larger common plan: exemption applies — but § 12-7-6(b) minimum standards and buffers still bind, and any work near a stream, lake, or trout water gets flagged to the local issuing authority first		
☐	If not exempt: land disturbance permit obtained from the certified local issuing authority (or EPD district where none) Authority: _____ Permit #: _____		
☐	If disturbing one acre or more: NPDES coverage under the right general permit (GAR100001 stand-alone); NOI filed with EPD and the waiting period confirmed against the current permit text NOI filed: _____		

O.C.G.A. § 12-7-7(a); § 12-7-17(4); § 12-7-6(b) obligation noted without printed distances. NPDES permit family and forms: EPD storm-water forms page (epd.georgia.gov). EPD-hosted documents state the 2023 permits run through July 2028 and authorize discharge 14 days after a complete NOI — this kit treats both as unconfirmed; read the current GAR100001 before you schedule around them. Verified August 2026.

E. DRIVEWAY — GDOT IF YOU TOUCH A STATE ROUTE

If your driveway connects to a **state route**, GDOT's driveway and encroachment regulations control: "A permit is required prior to performing any construction work or non-routine maintenance within" the state highway right of way, and "Application for residential driveways and temporary use driveways are made at the District Area Office." The statute behind it (§ 32-6-131) bars unpermitted **commercial** driveways — and the regulations classify any driveway serving more than four dwelling units as commercial. A county or city road instead? The county or city sets the rules — ask public works.

E1: Driveway access

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Determined whether the road you connect to is a state route, a county road, or a city street — this decides who you talk to		
☐	If a state route: residential driveway application obtained from and filed with the GDOT District Area Office — original forms only District/Area office: _____ Filed: _____		
☐	Permit in hand before any work in the right of way — including culvert, apron, or grading at the road		
☐	If county or city road: their driveway/culvert requirements confirmed and any permit obtained		

GDOT Regulations for Driveway and Encroachment Control (read directly, dot.ga.gov); O.C.G.A. § 32-6-131. Verified August 2026.

F. NOTICE OF COMMENCEMENT — 15 DAYS, OR YOU LOSE THE SCREEN

Georgia's lien law gives an owner one cheap, powerful filing: "Not later than 15 days after the contractor physically commences work on the property, a notice of commencement shall be filed by the owner, the agent of the owner, or by the contractor with the clerk of the superior court in the county in which the project is located. A copy of the notice of commencement shall be posted on the project site." (§ 44-14-361.5(b)) Filing it activates the Notice-to-Contractor screen that cuts off hidden remote lien claimants — the suppliers and sub-subs you never met. Not filing forfeits exactly that (§ 44-14-361.5(d)).

F1: Notice of Commencement

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Drafted with the statutory contents: contractor's name, address, and phone; project name, location, and legal description; owner's name and address; the person at whose instance improvements are made, if not the owner; surety, if bonded; construction lender, if any		
☐	Filed with the clerk of superior court in the project county within 15 days of physically commencing work Filed: _____ Book/page: _____		
☐	Copy posted on the project site and kept posted; stamped copy in this binder		

O.C.G.A. § 44-14-361.5(b), (d); statutory contents list per subsection (b). No state form exists — some clerks publish fill-in templates; draft to the contents list either way. Verified August 2026.

G. CODE EDITIONS AND THE TWO MANDATORY ENERGY TESTS

Effective January 1, 2026, Georgia's DCA adopted new mandatory state codes: the **2024** IRC, IBC, IPC, IMC, IFGC, and ISPSC, each with 2026 Georgia Amendments, plus the **2023 NEC** (and a 2024 IFC through the Safety Fire Commissioner). The amendments packet itself: *"The INTERNATIONAL RESIDENTIAL CODE FOR ONE- AND TWO-FAMILY DWELLINGS, 2024 Edition ... shall constitute the official Georgia State Minimum Standard One- and Two-Family Dwelling Code."*

Georgia guts three parts of the IRC — buy the right books

The 2026 Georgia Amendments delete the IRC's energy part ("*Part IV, Energy Conservation (Chapter 11), is deleted*"), its plumbing part ("*Part VII, Plumbing (Chapters 25 through 33), is deleted*"), and its electrical part ("*Part VIII, Electrical (Chapters 34 through 43), is deleted from the INTERNATIONAL RESIDENTIAL CODE*"). Your plumbing is inspected to the state IPC, your wiring to the 2023 NEC, and your energy work to the Georgia Energy Code — not to IRC chapters. An IRC-only bookshelf will not cover your house.

One relief: by statute, no state or post-2010 local code *"shall include a requirement that fire sprinklers be installed in a single-family dwelling or a residential building that contains no more than two dwelling units"* (§ 8-2-4, quoted in the DCA packet).

DCA, "New Mandatory State Codes" announcement and current-state-minimum-codes page (dca.georgia.gov); 2026 Georgia Amendments packet ("Revised January 1, 2026"), read directly. Verified August 2026 — if you file before a county has caught up, confirm which edition its reviewers are working from.

The energy code did not move. It remains the **2015 IECC** with the Georgia Supplements and Amendments (2020, 2022, 2022-additional, and 2023) — untouched by the 2026 cycle: "*The INTERNATIONAL ENERGY CONSERVATION CODE, 2015 Edition ... shall constitute the official Georgia State Minimum Standard Energy Code.*" (Ga. Comp. R. & Regs. 110-11-1-.34) Buy the 2015 book and the Georgia amendment packets, not a newer IECC.

Two tests are mandatory — there is no visual-inspection option

Blower door. "*All one and two-family dwelling units shall be tested and verified to less than five air changes per hour at 50 Pascals (ACH50) for Climate Zones 2, 3, and 4. ... A written report of the results of the test shall be signed by the party conducting the test and provided to the code official. ... Testing shall be conducted by a certified duct and envelope tightness (DET) verifier.*" (GA amended IECC § R402.4.1.2) Unlike some states, Georgia offers no visual-inspection alternative — plan and budget for the test.

Duct leakage. "*Ducts shall be pressure tested to determine air leakage*" (§ R403.3.3, Mandatory), at rough-in or post-construction, and "*the total leakage shall be less than or equal to 6 cubic feet per minute ... per 100 square feet ... of conditioned floor area*" (§ R403.3.4). One exception: "*A duct air leakage test shall not be required where the ducts and air handlers are located entirely within the building thermal envelope.*" Designing the ducts inside the envelope saves you the test — and energy.

G1: Energy code

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Certified DET verifier engaged for the blower door (and duct test if required) Verifier: _____ Cert #: _____		
☐	Insulation R-values, window/door U-factors and SHGC shown on the plans per the 2015 IECC with Georgia amendments		
☐	Ducts and air handlers entirely inside the thermal envelope? If yes, the duct test is excepted — note it on the plans Inside envelope? Y/N: _____		
☐	Blower door result under 5 ACH50 — signed written report to the code official and a copy in this binder Result: _____ Date: _____		
☐	Duct leakage at or under 6 cfm25/100 sq ft (unless excepted) — signed report retained Result: _____ Date: _____		

Ga. Comp. R. & Regs. 110-11-1-.34; Georgia amendments to the 2015 IECC — § R402.4.1.2 (2020 packet, effective January 1, 2020) and §§ R403.3.3, R403.3.4 with exception 1, read directly from the DCA amendment PDFs; the 2023 packet does not touch these sections. Verified August 2026.

Application filed: _____ Permit issued: _____ Permit #: _____

Sources — every Georgia claim in this document (verified August 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Eight mandatory codes statewide with no local adoption; permissive codes only where adopted	§ 8-2-25(a), (b)
Permits/inspections a local-option power; private professional providers	§ 8-2-26(a)(4), (g)
Owner-builder work must conform to codes and any local permitting or inspection requirements	§ 43-41-17(h)
2024 I-Codes with 2026 GA Amendments and 2023 NEC effective January 1, 2026; IRC energy/plumbing/electrical parts deleted	DCA; 2026 GA Amendments packet
No mandatory fire sprinklers in one- and two-family dwellings	§ 8-2-4 (in DCA packet)
Energy code is the 2015 IECC with Georgia Supplements and Amendments	Ga. Comp. R. & Regs. 110-11-1-.34
Blower door mandatory (< 5 ACH50, DET verifier, signed report); duct test mandatory ($\leq$ 6 cfm25/100 sq ft) unless ducts inside the envelope	GA IECC R402.4.1.2; R403.3.3–.3.4
No physical development of a septic lot before the county construction permit; 20-day decision; 12-month validity; site inspection first	DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03
Owner may drill a well on own primary-residence property; resale development requires a licensed contractor	§ 12-5-131.1(a)
Land-disturbance permit or NOI required; single-family exemption under one acre; minimum standards still apply when exempt	§ 12-7-7(a); § 12-7-17(4); § 12-7-6(b)
NPDES construction general permits GAR100001/2/3	EPD, epd.georgia.gov
Notice of Commencement: 15 days, superior court clerk, posted on site; failure forfeits the screen	§ 44-14-361.5(b), (d)
GDOT permit for work in state right of way; residential applications at the District Area Office	GDOT regs; § 32-6-131

Read any O.C.G.A. section cited above at **codes.findlaw.com/ga** — pattern: codes.findlaw.com/ga/title-43-professions-and-businesses/ga-code-sect-43-41-17/ with the title and section swapped in — or through the official O.C.G.A. portal linked from legis.ga.gov. Statute text was verified August 2026 against that mirror, whose stated currency was March 28, 2024; the 2024–2025 session laws (SB 503, HB 635, SB 125) postdate it. None is reported to change the owner-exemption text this kit quotes, but confirm exact wording at the official code before you rely on it.